

Complexity bias leads us to *prefer* complex solutions over simple ones. The trouble with choosing complicated is that our brains prefer simple. It's why cognitive biases exist in the first place! For example, when sixty women were asked to give a tour of their home,² the ones who believed that their home was cluttered had increased cortisol levels in response to the request and were more likely to feel constantly tired and exhibit symptoms of depression. Another study found³ that participants who felt they had a chaotic kitchen made poorer food choices than those who felt they were in control of their kitchen.

Our propensity toward complexity fills our daily lives with thousands of little things to think about. What to eat, what to wear, who to call, or where to go, all of it piles up, taking precious brain space and pushing out or making other, possibly more important, decisions overwhelming. It's called decision fatigue, and when this happens, it leads us to choose the path of least resistance, which usually costs money.

We think of our mental capacity like a balloon. The air we blow into that balloon is all the daily demands, choices, and considerations of life. There's room for quite a bit of air, and some people's balloons are able to hold more than others. But something that all balloons have in common is that eventually, when filled too much, they pop!

We've all been there. Overextending beyond our capacity and "popping." Whether in the form of lashing out, shutting down, giving up, abandoning plans, or powering through despite detriment to ourselves. It happens. But even worse than popping, we often don't solve the problems that got us there in the first place. We just grab another balloon and keep filling it with the same type and amount of air, hoping this time this balloon will be limitless. They never are.

Instead, what if we learned to operate within the confines of that balloon? To become familiar with our capacities, know what's enough, what's too much, and how to let some of that air out every once in a while?

When we can find room for making decisions simpler, eliminate unnecessary choices, and decrease complexity, the less likely we are to pop. Instead of choosing complexity that leads to stress spending and burnout, what if we intentionally committed to simplicity?